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INDIA D2C SKINCARE · CONSUMER LANDSCAPE STUDY 2026

4,715 Indian skincare consumers told us why they buy, stay and switch.

First-hand evidence for D2C skincare brands: what wins the first purchase, what earns the second, and where local brands lose ground to imports.

4,715	270	18	100%
verified consumers sharing how they buy, use and switch	cities and towns across Tier 1, 2 and 3 India	behavioural signals, each verified with an in-home product photo	zero-party: every consumer finding is first-hand, none scraped or modelled



One shelf, a full routine



Most-used: moisturiser



Heritage local cream



Ingredient-led cleanser

COMPETITIVE LANDSCAPE

Local brands are bought on **price** and lost on **trust**. Imports win on the opposite.

THE BATTLEGROUND

43.5% use local and imported brands side by side: the most winnable customer in the category.

VALIDATION

Price wins trial, but only **1.5%** say affordability is what they love about the product they keep.

RETENTION

45% of "very happy" customers still switch. Satisfaction is not loyalty.

WHY THIS MATTERS NOW

The market now rewards brands that truly know their consumer.

Consumers reward the brands that understand them, with repeat purchases, referrals and loyalty. Yet most brands in the Rs 10 to 100 Cr band still read their customer through platform dashboards, not first-hand evidence.

THE MARKET · SECONDARY SOURCES

USD 23B → 40B

India beauty and personal care, FY25 to FY30, with online rising from ~20% to 34 to 38% of spend.[1]

3 exits in 18 months

HUL bought Minimalist, L'Oreal bought Innovist (CCI cleared Sep 2026), Wipro bought Dermatouch.[2,3,4]

60 to 65%

of D2C brands stuck at Rs 1 to 50 Cr; 70%+ depend on Meta; repeat rates typically 10 to 30%.[5]

FIRST-HAND: WHAT 4,715 CONSUMERS TOLD US

A high-frequency category, discovered on social and won on recommendation

59.1% bought a skincare product in the last two weeks

71.4% use skincare every day

51.3% discover new products on social media first

75.8% have bought a product because someone recommended it

75.9% would try a new brand from a free sample (yes or maybe)

What matters most when choosing

What it does for my skin	29.5%
Natural or organic ingredients	23.3%
Price or affordability	21.8%
Trusted brand	20.7%
Reviews or recommendations	2.8%

Four drivers sit within 9 points of each other. No single message owns the category; the brands that test are the brands that win.

Where they actually buy

Local store	37.6%
Online store	25.9%
Pharmacy	16.1%
Supermarket	13.2%
Beauty shop or salon	4.0%

Discovery is digital; purchase is still largely physical. Platform data sees only half the journey.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR BRAND

Your consumer is back in the market every few weeks, discovering on social and trusting friends' recommendations. Each time they restock, they reconsider, and a competitor has a real chance to win them over. The brands that grow know **why** they were chosen this cycle, not just that they were.

LOCAL VS IMPORTED BRANDS

Local brands are bought on price and lost on trust.

We segmented every respondent by the type of brand they prefer, then compared how each group chooses, buys, discovers and leaves. Every gap shown is statistically significant.

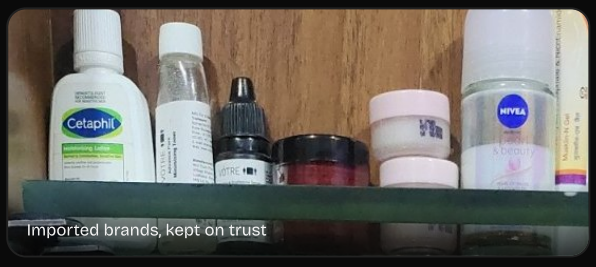


SHARE OF EACH GROUP	LOCAL	IMPORTED
WHY THEY CHOOSE		
Price is the #1 reason to choose	31.0%	17.9%
Trusted brand is the #1 reason	11.1%	27.2%
WHERE THEY BUY AND DISCOVER		
Buy mainly at a local store	52.5%	27.8%
Buy mainly online	18.6%	31.1%
Discover via friends and family	26.2%	12.8%
Discover via social media	44.1%	56.0%
HOW LOYAL THEY ARE		
Switch products sometimes or very often	55.7%	45.4%
Have never dropped a product	25.2%	39.6%
WHAT THEY LOVE ABOUT THE PRODUCT THEY KEEP		
"It smells nice"	24.1%	13.1%
"It protects me from the sun"	1.4%	8.3%

Local n=1,035, imported n=1,139. Every gap shown differs at p<0.001 (two-proportion z-test).



Local brand, sold on volume: "33% extra"



Imported brands, kept on trust

The swing segment

43.5% use both. They discover on social (53.4%) and, once settled, rarely move: 55.8% switch rarely or never. Win them once and they stay.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR BRAND

Indian D2C brands are not losing on efficacy: both groups value "what it does for my skin" equally (31.1% vs 28.8%). They are losing on **trust**, and discounting to compensate. The edge comes from knowing exactly which proof moves your competitor's customer: the ingredient story, a dermatologist, peer reviews or a sample in hand.

WHAT WINS TRIAL VS WHAT KEEPS CUSTOMERS

Price gets you in the basket. Experience keeps you there.

Why consumers choose, stay and leave point in three different directions. That gap is where brands misread their own data.

21.8%
choose a product mainly on price

27.6%
have dropped a product for being too expensive

1.5%
say affordability is what they love about the product they kept

What they love about the product they use most

It feels good on my skin	39.6%
Keeps skin soft or moisturised	23.6%
It smells nice	15.2%
Brightens or evens skin tone	9.1%
Helps with acne or blemishes	5.4%
Protects me from the sun	4.9%
It's affordable	1.5%

Sensory experience outranks every functional claim. Most ad copy leads with the claim.

Why they stopped using a product

Too expensive	27.6%
It caused a skin reaction	25.8%
Didn't work as expected	13.3%
Switched to another brand	11.9%
Never stopped using one	33.8%

One in four has quit a product over a skin reaction: a formulation and claims problem that reviews rarely surface early.



Tan removal, brand one



Tan removal, brand two

44.6%
of **"very happy"** consumers still switch sometimes or very often. Same promise, different brand: satisfaction does not predict retention.

50.4% vs 39.6%
of Tier 2/3 consumers switch sometimes or very often, vs Tier 1. Middle India is the more contestable market (p<0.001).

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR BRAND

Discounts may win the first purchase, but they rarely earn the second. Validate the experience (texture, feel, scent, skin tolerance) with the exact consumers you want to win, **before** you invest in positioning it as your value driver.

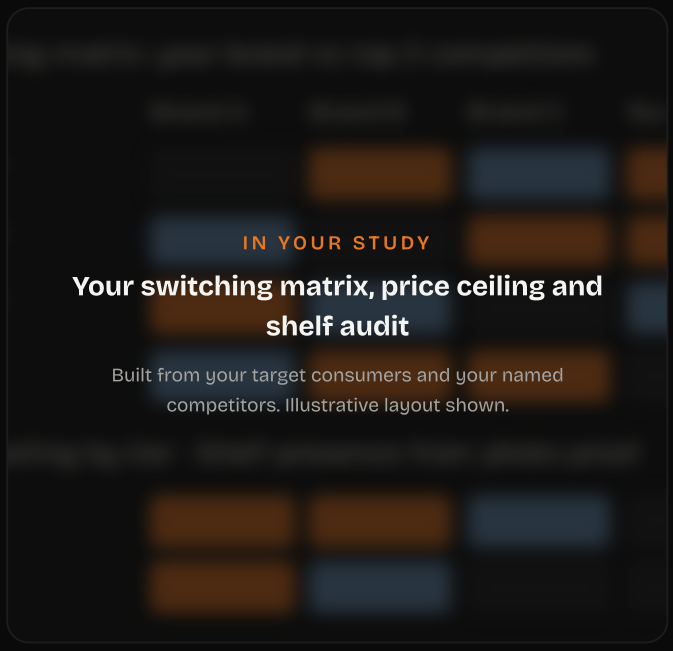
FROM INSIGHT TO ACTION

One study just mapped an entire category. Your curated study, shows you how to win it.

An Altilos Expert study reaches up to 750 verified consumers, scoped to your category, competitors, cities and next big decision.

Questions your study can answer

- Which competitor's customers will switch to you, and what proof moves them — COMPETITIVE
- Does your texture, scent and tolerance hold up against the brand they use today — VALIDATION
- What price your target customer will pay before quitting, by city tier — PRICING
- Which brands are actually on their shelf, verified by photo — SHELF PROOF
- Which offer converts a sample into a second purchase — CONVERSION



IN YOUR STUDY

Your switching matrix, price ceiling and shelf audit

Built from your target consumers and your named competitors. Illustrative layout shown.

PICK YOUR DEPTH · ONE-TIME, PER STUDY

Pulse	Core	Core+	Expert
₹8,000	₹40,000	₹1,00,000	₹2,00,000
50 consumers	200 consumers	350 consumers	750 consumers
Fast read on one question before you commit spend.	Validate a launch, claim or price point with your target buyer.	Competitive read across cities and segments.	Full landscape plus targeted offers to competitor users.

Know your consumer, better than the competition.

Configure your study in minutes. Decision-ready insights in days, not quarters.

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Methodology. Zero-party study of 4,715 verified consumers across 270 Indian cities and towns, collected first-hand through Altilos' verified respondent pools (Rwazi mappers) in April 2026. Each respondent answered 18 behavioural questions and verified their response with a photo of a skincare product they own. Margin of error ±1.4 points at 95% confidence for the full sample; subgroup comparisons tested with two-proportion z-tests and reported only where $p<0.05$. Tier 1 covers the eight metros and their satellite cities; respondents without a recorded city are excluded from tier comparisons. The sample skews male (88%) and towards lower incomes, so findings best represent the mass and mass-premium consumer. A commissioned study sets quotas to your exact target, for example affluent women aged 18 to 35 in Tier 1 and Tier 2 cities. All product photos are respondent submissions from Altilos studies.

Market sources.

1. Redseer, India BPC 2030: Growth Shifts and Opportunities, Feb 2026
2. Inc42, HUL-owned Minimalist FY26 results, Aug 2026
3. Personal Care Insights, L'Oreal clears Innovist deal, Sep 2026
4. YourStory, Wipro Consumer Care acquires Dermatouch, Aug 2026
5. DSG Consumer Partners, Meta and Viralmint founder survey, via Entrepreneur India, Dec 2025